

# Crunchbang Linux

## Minimalist and Mac-Friendly

For resource-conscious Linux users, Crunchbang Linux is the right flavour. It is a Debian-based GNU/Linux distro that uses the nimble Openbox window manager, with pre-installed apps chosen for minimum load on system resources. Yet, it provides vast functionality, right out-of-the-box. This review comes along with a short 'how-to' for installing it on Apple hardware.

Lately, there has been a lot of talk about Crunchbang Linux in the FOSS community regarding its robustness, stability, and how productive it enables people to be. Some emphasise its Debian roots; though until version 9 it was based on Ubuntu. From version 10 a.k.a. Slatter, and the testing releases of version 11 Waldorf, the distribution's base switched to Debian 6 (Squeeze) and the testing version of Debian 7 (Wheezy), respectively.

Let's give it a test run. The project's website <http://www.crunchbang.org/> provides ISO images for the stable (ver 10) and testing (11) releases, both for direct downloads or via BitTorrent. I went for version 11 (Waldorf). I wanted to make a bootable USB flash drive, but UNetBootin failed to create a working image, so I used the method recommended by the official installation guide—use the 'dd' utility found in almost all modern Linux distros. A single Google search led to a thread in the forums (which are very helpful). It described the process, with the exact commands to use. Note that this completely erases and overwrites your flash drive; so back up any data you want from the drive before you do this. Replace the path `/home/aditya/downloads/crunchbang11.iso` with the path to the ISO on your system, and '`sdb`' with your system's device node for your USB drive. Note that the image is not to be written to a partition of the flash drive (e.g., '`sdb1`') but to the drive itself (e.g., '`sdb`'). Here's the command I ran:



**Note:** Although I have tried these steps and installed all software I recommend, and have found that it has in no way damaged anything on my Mac, I take no responsibility for any data or material loss, although there is absolutely no risk if the instructions are carried out properly.

```
sudo dd if=/home/aditya/downloads/crunchbang11.iso of=/dev/sdb bs=4M; sync
```

Installation was pretty straight-forward; i.e., graphical, like

many mainstream distros. Partitioning the hard disk was simple with GParted. The installation took almost eight minutes, which is reasonable for a standard 5400 rpm hard drive.

The default desktop (Figure 1) is a hybrid of Openbox and XFCE with Conky and Tint2 panels, and effectively conveys the distro's nature—functional minimalism. The default open source X.Org drivers supported my AMD-ATI and NVIDIA GeForce video cards well enough to play 3D games like Armagetron. All hardware on my MacBook Pro 7, ThinkPad x120e and ThinkPad x220 are supported out-of-the-box.

Right after the first boot, you are presented with a script (Figure 2) to install LibreOffice, printer support, Java and LAMP tools, with other Debian development packages. The script also offers the following commands:

```
sudo apt get update
```

```
... and
```

```
sudo apt get dist update.
```

The script is quite a nice feature.

Moving on to default applications, VLC is the media player—no codecs problems so almost all media formats work. We have Thunar for file management and Terminator for the terminal emulator.

Chromium is the default browser, Abiword the word processor and Gnumeric is for spreadsheets. GCC and the basic GNU tool-chain are included, which is appreciated by all programmers. Plus we have Python 2.7, and Geany for the text editor or the IDE—just right for minimalists. There's the (non-free but very precise) ANSI art software, Figlet, with the usual geek amusement trio: *Fortune*, *Cowsay* and *Cowthink*.

The system is as stable as any OS could be—although it's labelled 'testing', it is quite stable compared to Ubuntu. In my own